

Samuel Finley Breese Morse

Developed the Morse code along with Alfred Vail after the untimely death of his wife due to illness

1896

Guglielmo Marconi transceived his first radio signal in Italy over a distance of 6 kilometres

Feature

Andaman and Nicobar Islands. The team was on the islands during the 2004 Indian Ocean earthquake. Following the earthquake and tsunami, the ARSI team began immediate amateur radio emergency communications from two stations on the islands, one at Port Blair and the other on Car Nicobar. These were the only effective communications from the territory to the rest of the world for 10 days following the disaster.

Getting started

If you prefer a structured approach you can get involved in the amateur radio field by finding a local club. The club will provide you information about getting licensed and local operating practices. They will also provide technical advice like information about purchasing equipment locally. Many clubs organise meetings and classes to teach the basic skills of radio operation and prepare you for the Ham radio license test. You can also do it yourself by reading books or getting help from another amateur radio operator.

Ham meets are also organised. In India too. Hamfest has become popular since 1991 and last year it was held in Bengaluru - The Garden City of India along with Golden Jubilee Celebrations of Bangalore Amateur Radio Club VU2ARC.

Equipment Purchased

Most Amateurs purchase a handheld VHF or UHF (or a combined "dual-band" VHF+UHF) radio. You can optionally connect an external antenna at your home for extended range. A mere handheld, running at low power, is sufficient to gain access to most local repeaters so this is plenty to get you started.

The price of these handhelds can be obtained from manufacturers as per make and features. Some popular brands are Alinco, Icom, Kenwood and Yaesu.

Self Made

Amateur Radio Transceivers can be made by enthusiasts with locally available components. Several Hams have come

up with their circuit design, PCBs and construction of low cost amateur Radio equipment. Assume that you have just passed the Restricted Grade-II class "no code" license and are looking for a radio.

License and Examination Details

Amateur radio operators have to qualify in an examination conducted by Ministry of Communications, Government of India and obtain license for operating / possessing a Radio Station. Any individual above the age of 12 is permitted to appear for Amateur Station Operator License Examination and no educational qualification is prescribed. It takes just two months (say two hours a day training) to become eligible for the examination.

One should qualify a simple test conducted in three subjects namely,

- I) Morse Code (Transmission & Reception)
- II) Communication Procedure
- III) Basic Electronics.

The Officer-In-Charge, Wireless Monitoring Station, Dept. of Telecommunication under Ministry of Communication, is the authority for conducting these tests in their own town provided there are sufficient number of applicants. The licences are issued by Wireless Planning & Co-ordination Wing of DOT, after passing the test in any of the following grades:

1. Restricted Grade II - Permitting use of VHF/UHF only (i.e Walkie-Talkies).
2. Grade II - Permitting HF/VHF/UHF frequencies but with limited transmitting power.
3. Grade I- Permitting all amateur frequencies with higher power including latest techniques.
4. Advance Grade- Permitting higher power and advanced techniques including Satellite Communication.

The ability to handle Morse Code at the rate of 5 words per minutes sending-receiving will make you eligible to get



The basic Ham equipment in use

grade-II and 12 words per minutes sending-receiving will get grade-I. For advanced grade higher level of technical knowledge in electronics is essentially required. Basic knowledge can be obtained by purchasing study manuals, books on Morse Code from any of the amateur clubs.

The exam fee should be paid in the form of Demand Draft drawn only from State bank of India in favour of "Pay & Accounts Officer (Head Quarters), Department of Telecommunications, New Delhi" and payable at New Delhi service Branch No:7687. The fees is as follows: Grade II & Restricted Grade II is Rs.10 each, while Grade I is Rs.20 and Advance Grade is Rs.25.

Local clubs

For those that like a structured approach, many clubs organise meetings and classes to teach the basic skills of radio operation and prepare people for their Ham radio license test. At the end of the classes, a test is given. If you pass, you're a Ham! There are clubs in Delhi, Mumbai, Kolkatta and Chennai. Every month meets are held in Ahmedabad, Hyderabad and Nagpur. Similarly, hams meetup in January, March, June, August, October and December in Ajmer, Bangalore, Darjeeling, Gorakhpur, Jalandhar, Goa, Mangalore, Shillong, Ranchi, Srinagar and such other places where a monitoring station of the Monitoring Organisation of the Ministry of Communications is located. 

